

something called as Render Using Maya Software and a drop down menu that also includes Maya Hardware renderer. Maya has another renderer called Mental Ray. If it's not there in your drop down, then go to **Windows > Setting / Preferences > Plug-in manager** and locate a file called **Matatmr.mll**. Click on **Load** and you'll see the mental ray in the "Render Using" dropdown Menubox. Let's make one change here before we go ahead with lighting.

Open the Render settings, and go to the Common tab. Scroll down to the bottom and open the Render option menu. Uncheck the **Enable Default Lights** button and close the window. This will take all the lights that were lighting the scene by default. If you render a single frame now by clicking on the black button, you will notice that the whole render has gone black, but, if you click on the white button that says **Display Alpha Channel** beside the RGB channel button, you'll notice that the shot does have an alpha channel to it, but only because there is no sign of light in the scene, it looks black.

Now that we know what rendering is, let's add a directional light in the shot. To do this, go to **Create > Lights > Directional Light**. Directional light doesn't depend on the position or scaling, but on rotating, place the light in an angle you'd prefer, and render the image. You will be able to see some light that is hitting the object. Naturally, you won't be able to see the light source. You can rotate the directional light in all 360 degrees and see how it's affecting the objects.

With the Directional light selected, go to the Attribute Editor and look at the first option that says Type. This is also a place where you can specify which light you would like to use from the drop down box. The default here is white, but sometimes when there is some blue light or an orange light from the sky.

Next is the intensity slider. The default value is 1, but in case there is a stronger source of light, then it is suggested to tweak it accordingly. Decay Rate Specific to Spot, Area, and Point lights, this attribute determines the rate at which the light intensity fades (decreases) at a distance.

The next thing we tweak is the shadows. Click on the small arrow beside shadows, which will open up the menu and show a bunch of attributes attached to it. You can click the checkbox, which says "Use Depth Map Shadows". This will enable normal shadows. Hit the current render button and see how it looks. Shadows will appear in the render that you just did. If you zoom in a little bit more, you will notice that the shadows are tearing